BRUGES, BELGIUM

Groeningemuseum: Masterpieces

Twenty works at the Groeningemuseum, from the closeness of a portrait to the distance of a river horizon.



Margareta van Eyck has very little space around her. The folds of her headdress seem almost to fill what her face leaves unoccupied. Elsewhere in this selection, rivers and skies open far beyond the people who inhabit them. That difference in distance offers a useful way through the Groeningemuseum's varied collection.

The religious and judicial scenes bring another question: who stands near the central event, and who witnesses it? A donor kneels among saints; mourners gather at a bed; witnesses surround an accused judge. These arrangements are worth comparing before separating the pictures into periods. The twenty works below are a selection to study, rather than a route through the galleries.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/groeningemuseum

The selection · 20

1. Margareta van Eyck
   Jan van Eyck · 1439
2. Death of the Virgin
   Hugo van der Goes · after 1475–1482
3. The Last Judgement
   Hieronymus Bosch · c. 1500
4. La Mare aux Fées, Fontainebleau
   Alphonse Asselbergs · c. 1876
5. The Arrest of Sisamnes
   Gerard David · 1498
6. Banquet
   Antonius Claeissens · 1574
7. The Baptism of Christ
   Gerard David · c. 1502 - circa 1508
8. Self-Portrait
   James Ensor · c. 1885
9. Company Making Music and Drinking in an Inn
   Dirck Hals · c. 1627
10. Jan van Eyewerve
    Pourbus Pieter · 1551
11. Jacquemyne Buuck
    Pourbus Pieter · 1551
12. Italianate Landscape with a Market Scene
    Peeter van Bredael · c. 1680
13. Saint Luke Painting the Madonna
    Lancelot Blondeel · 1545
14. Winter Music
    Léon Spilliaert · 1943
15. River Landscape
    Jan van Goyen · 1644
16. Isabella of Portugal with Saint Elizabeth
    Petrus Christus · 1457-1460
17. Madonna with Canon Joris van der Paele
    Jan van Eyck · 1436
18. Mountains near Voreppe
    Théodore Fourmois · 1850
19. Mouth of the River Scheldt
    Paul Jean Clays · c. 1852 - circa 1875
20. Franciscus Josephus Kinsoen
    Jean Baptiste van Acker · c. 1825 - circa 1830

01 / 20

Margareta van Eyck

Jan van Eyck

1439 · Oil on oak · Groeningemuseum



Jan van Eyck; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The white headdress gives the face a sharply folded surround, while the hands settle the lower edge. Nothing needs to happen for the portrait to hold its ground. Compare the changes within the cloth with the steadier surfaces of the face: the sitter's presence depends partly on what surrounds her, not only on the accuracy of her features.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0162.I

02 / 20

Death of the Virgin

Hugo van der Goes

after 1475–1482 · Groeningemuseum



Hugo van der Goes. Death of the Virgin. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The apostles crowd around Mary's bed, but they do not merge into a single expression of grief. Faces and hands keep drawing attention away from the body and back again. The museum's recent research also found evidence of painted curtains and earlier cropping: even the boundaries through which this gathering is seen have a history.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Last Judgement

Hieronymus Bosch

c. 1500 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Hieronymus Bosch. Last Judgement. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/hieronymus-bosch/last-judgement · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The multitude of small incidents can make the triptych difficult to take in. Start with its large divisions: paradise on the left, judgment in the centre and hell on the right. The unsettling point is that the central earthly world already resembles a place of punishment. The strange creatures belong to that argument, rather than being detachable curiosities.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

La Mare aux Fées, Fontainebleau

Alphonse Asselbergs

c. 1876 · Oil on canvas · Groeningemuseum



Alphonse Asselbergs; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

There is no commanding mountain or landmark to organise this woodland view. Instead, the edge of the pool keeps changing direction between grasses and trees. Following it draws attention to the uneven meeting of land and water. The broad sky gives this modest patch of ground room without turning it into a grand prospect.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0008.I

05 / 20

The Arrest of Sisamnes

Gerard David

1498 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Gerard David; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

Hands point toward the seated man while the surrounding faces hold him under scrutiny. David makes accusation a public situation, not a private exchange between two people. The rich clothing matters to that effect: these witnesses inhabit an ordered civic world. Their proximity makes the accused man's place within it suddenly precarious.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0040.I

06 / 20

Banquet

Antonius Claeissens

1574 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Antonius Claeissens; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

A feast normally surrounds its guests with things to eat and people to speak to. Here the front-facing arrangement also exposes them to another audience, outside the picture. Elaborate clothes, vessels and decoration become a display of plenty. Compare this formal presentation with the overlapping, less orderly exchanges in Dirck Hals's inn scene.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0023.I

07 / 20

The Baptism of Christ

Gerard David

c. 1502 - circa 1508 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Gerard David; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The raised vessel identifies the decisive action, but the landscape continues well beyond it. Small gaps around the principal figures keep the baptism legible amid this abundance. David does not have to empty the world to distinguish a sacred event within it: space and measured gestures do that work.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0035.I

08 / 20

Self-Portrait

James Ensor

c. 1885 · Conté · Groeningemuseum



James Ensor; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

Much of the sheet remains unoccupied around Ensor's inclined head. The marks gather where the likeness needs them and loosen elsewhere, allowing the paper to remain an active part of the image. Set it beside Margareta van Eyck: a recognisable person can emerge through selective drawing as well as through a closely described painted surface.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO1274r.II

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Company Making Music and Drinking in an Inn

Dirck Hals

c. 1627 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Dirck Hals; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

A glass, an instrument and an extended hand each connect one person to another. These small actions supply the gathering's structure; no single figure needs to command it. Beside Claeissens's banquet, the difference is clear. This company is held together by things happening across the table rather than by a collective pose.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0252.I

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Jan van Eyewerve

Pourbus Pieter

1551 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Pieter Pourbus; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The coat of arms and the city beyond the opening give the sitter an identity larger than his face alone. They locate him within a public world, while his dark clothes keep the figure visually compact. Read this with the neighboring portrait of Jacquemyne Buuck, where the arrangement answers his across a separate panel.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0108.I

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Jacquemyne Buuck

Pourbus Pieter

1551 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Pieter Pourbus; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The white collar cuts a distinct shape into the black dress, drawing attention upward from the hands to the face. The small dog introduces a different scale of presence below. Seen with Jan van Eyewerve's portrait, the reversed arrangement makes the two panels work as a pair without depriving either sitter of a separate space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0109.I

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Italianate Landscape with a Market Scene

Peeter van Bredael

c. 1680 · Oil on canvas · Groeningemuseum



Peeter van Bredael; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

Market business carries on beneath architecture much larger than the people using it. Traders and animals occupy the ground while the arch opens onto a more distant world. The antique setting gives ordinary exchange an imposing frame; the activity, in turn, stops the ruins from becoming an empty display of architectural grandeur.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0149.I

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Saint Luke Painting the Madonna

Lancelot Blondeel

1545 · Oil on canvas · Groeningemuseum



Lancelot Blondeel; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The painter saint's encounter with the Madonna occupies surprisingly little of an image dominated by ornament. Columns and arches provide an elaborate approach to that small centre. The setting therefore asks for attention in its own right: painting a sacred subject here also involves constructing an architectural world around it.

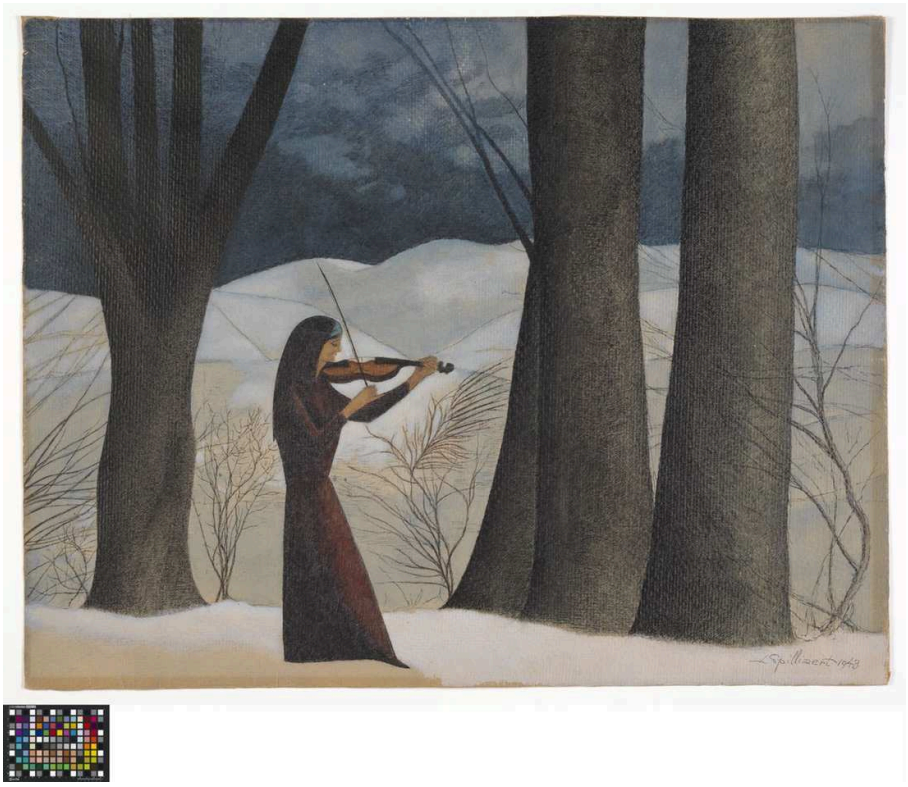
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0018.I

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Winter Music

Léon Spilliaert

1943 · Oost-indische inkt en waterverf · Groeningemuseum



Leon Spilliaert; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The violinist's curved posture interrupts the repeated vertical trunks. Snow leaves the surrounding ground sparse, giving her action an unusually isolated setting. Music cannot be heard in a painting, but the relationship between the single figure and the measured spacing of trees makes the title more than a description of someone holding an instrument.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1976.GRO0813.II

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River Landscape

Jan van Goyen

1644 · Oil on panel · Groeningemuseum



Jan Josefsz. van Goyen; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

A brown sail is enough to register strongly against the grey river and sky. Most of the distance is built from quieter tonal changes, so the boats do not need sharply separated colours to establish their positions. With so much space above the low horizon, the landscape's character depends heavily on weather.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0163.I

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Isabella of Portugal with Saint Elizabeth

Petrus Christus

1457-1460 · Groeningemuseum



Petrus Christus. Isabella Of Portugal With St. Elizabeth. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The kneeling donor and her accompanying saint occupy a space that leads outward through an arch. As a triptych wing, the panel belongs to a larger devotional arrangement, now difficult to understand from this image alone. The donor's prayer is consequently both an individual act and a gesture directed beyond the surviving scene's boundaries.

Object source · Open artwork

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Madonna with Canon Joris van der Paele

Jan van Eyck

1436 · Oil on oak · Groeningemuseum



Jan van Eyck; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The canon's white clothing sits among embroidered robes, stone and shining armour. These materials distinguish the figures without breaking their close assembly around Mary and the child. Compare the canon with Margareta van Eyck: here a particular, aging face is placed inside a sacred encounter, rather than isolated for a portrait.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0161.I

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Mountains near Voreppe

Théodore Fourmois

1850 · Oil on canvas · Groeningemuseum



Théodore Fourmois; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The people near the water remain small enough to measure the valley rather than dominate it. Their scale helps separate the immediate foreground from the mountains behind. The landscape offers several distances at once, asking the eye to move from human activity to terrain that extends well beyond its reach.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0058.I

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Mouth of the River Scheldt

Paul Jean Clays

c. 1852 - circa 1875 · Oil on canvas · Groeningemuseum





Paul Jean Clays; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The sails lean at different angles across the open water, giving the river a pattern of movement without closing it in. The larger tan sail establishes a nearer scale for the smaller vessels. Where Van Goyen's river relies on subdued tones, Clays makes the traffic itself a more conspicuous part of the view.

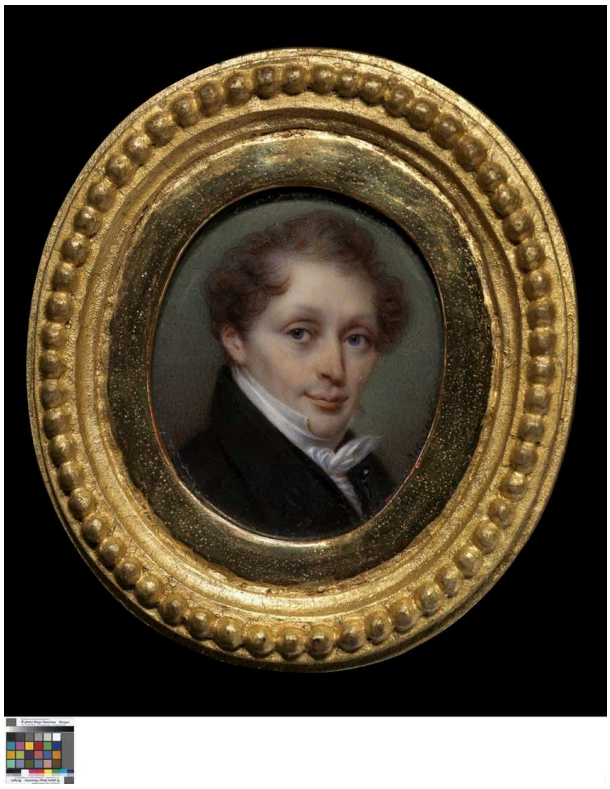
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0026.I

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Franciscus Josephus Kinsoen

Jean Baptiste van Acker

c. 1825 - circa 1830 · Oil on ivory · Groeningemuseum



Jean Baptiste van Acker; Groeningemuseum — Musea Brugge. Public domain / CC-PDM (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public domain / CC-PDM

The oval format admits little beyond the head, shoulders and pale collar. Unlike Pourbus's sitter with a city and coat of arms, Kinsoen has few surroundings through which to announce himself. The contrast between collar and coat concentrates the likeness, showing how tightly a portrait can be composed when its setting is withheld.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0000.GRO0076.I

Two distances to compare

Return to one portrait and one landscape after reading the selection. Notice how each gives—or denies—space around its subject. For a visit, check the museum's current information separately; collection records do not guarantee that every work is on display.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s notes on light, drapery and the arrangement of figures offer practical questions to bring to the early paintings. They provide a parallel Renaissance discussion, rather than evidence that these artists followed his advice.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12